

BREAKING BAD
A part of Chhangur's property being demolished in Madhpur, Jul. 8

conversion of upper-caste women was especially prized. In Lucknow, Gunja Gupta was allegedly lured by a Muslim man, Abu Ansari, posing as 'Amit', taken to Chhangur Baba's 'dargah', converted and married off under the new name of Alina Ansari. Similarly, Manvi Sharma from Auraiya accused a man named Meraj, alias Rudra, of emotional manipulation, sexual exploitation and forced conversion. The police FIR against Chhangur names five more such converted persons. In all, according to some estimates, it is suspected that over 1,000 people were converted by the baba's outfit.

These allegations have been fuelled by Gopal Rai, president of the right-wing outfit Vishva Hindu Raksha Parishad, who earlier paraded some of the alleged victims in front of the media in three press conferences in Lucknow, and claimed to have brought them back into the Hindu fold.

The FIR further states that Naveen and his wife Neetu and daughter Samale converted to Islam in Dubai at the Al Farooq Omar Bin Khatab Center in November 2015, with the couple allegedly being the leading lights of the racket. Their modus operandi was to lend large sums of money to vulnerable Hindus and force them to convert to Islam in exchange of writing off the debts when

ALL THE BIG CHARGES

The FIR by Uttar Pradesh ATS lines up a raft of grave accusations against Chhangur Baba

- **Involvement in illegal religious conversions through deceit, coercion and fear**
- **Acquiring money worth crores through foreign funding**
- **Spreading animosity against Hinduism**
- **Working to increase the population of Muslims, altering India's demography**
- **Trying to end India's democratic system and replace it with Sharia law, disturbing communal harmony**

SHOW, NOT TELL
Vishva Hindu Raksha Parishad chief Gopal Rai with some of Chhangur Baba's alleged victims in Lucknow, Jul. 22

they defaulted. The FIR claims the group targeted poor women, Dalits and daily wage workers for conversion. When their usual mix of financial help and religious brainwashing failed, the accused allegedly threatened to lodge false legal cases.

The FIR alleges the group acquired property worth over Rs 100 crore in a few years. One tract of land in Madhpur was purchased in the names of Neetu and Mehboob, and structures—including the now-demolished part—were built without required land-use approvals. Travel records show frequent UAE visits by Naveen and Neetu, often separately. Chhangur also visited Saudi Arabia in 2018. Officials suspect multiple passports, but say verification is ongoing.

The FIR concludes with the broader charge that the syndicate aimed to "spoil the harmony of the country" by spreading hatred towards the Hindu religion. It alleges that India's demography is being affected through such illegal conversions, with a goal to "remove the democratic system and establish Sharia Law".

However, investigators have yet to definitely name any foreign organisation or domestic group that allegedly funded or planned this grand conspiracy. The ED has flagged money trails, but whether they are linked to an ideological agenda or simply financial gain is still unclear.

Meanwhile, the state police claim to have 'busted' fresh 'conversion rackets'. On July 19, UP Police announced that they have arrested 10 people from six states after a probe into a missing persons complaint involving two sisters in Agra led them to what they described as a vast network pushing conversion and radicalisation involving funding from Canada and the US. The crackdown is part of 'Operation Asmita', a UP Police campaign launched to identify and dismantle such networks.

As the case draws national attention, rival political parties are busy blaming each other. The Samajwadi Party points to the expansion of Chhangur's racket under the BJP, while the BJP highlights his earlier links. If allegations of a campaign to subvert Indian democracy are true, then the question about how Chhangur operated so openly for so long must be answered. ■